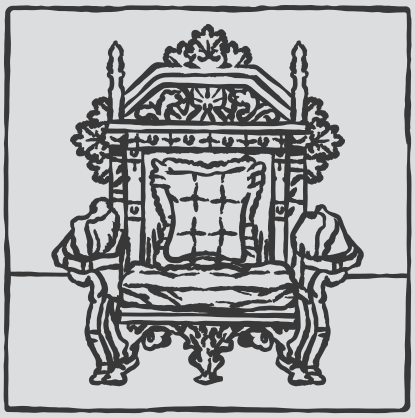


Christian Submission to Authority

Lesson 23 Questions

First Day: Read the Lesson 22 Notes.

The notes and lecture fortify the truth of the passage for understanding and application to daily life.

1. What from the lecture stood out to you regarding Christian love for all people, including our enemies?

2. How did the notes bring clarity to the doctrine of the cross for a believer?

Second Day: Read Romans 13:1.

Paul issued a demand regarding governing authorities.

3. Define "be subject to" or "submit."

4. a. Who is to submit to governing authorities, and why?

   b. Give reasons people struggle with submitting to authority. What is your greatest struggle?

5. When might it be acceptable in God's eyes to refuse to submit to authority? (See also Daniel 3; 6; Acts 5:29; or any other Scriptures you know.)

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Third Day: Read Romans 13:2-4.

Paul explained the consequence of refusal to submit to authority.

6. When people refuse to submit to lawful authority, against whom do they actually rebel, and what consequences do they face?

7. a. How can people be free from fear of those in authority?

   b. Give examples of how authorities can be God's servants for good, even if they are unbelievers. How could this bring a believer comfort?

8. Write a prayer to God regarding your submission to authority or lack thereof.

Fourth Day: Read Romans 13:5-7.

Paul gave reasons for the Roman believers to submit to authority.

9. a. What reasons did Paul give for submitting to authorities? What other reasons can you think of?

   b. What do you think Paul meant by the phrase "a matter of conscience"?

10. a. From verses 5 and 6, what are the purposes for paying taxes?

    b. Read Luke 20:22-25. What did Jesus say about paying taxes?

    c. How do these instructions guide your attitude about paying taxes?

Fifth Day: Reread Romans 13:1-7.

Paul exhorted believers to live rightly before God and others.

11. a. From the following verses, list those to whom we are to give respect and honor:

    Exodus 20:12

    Leviticus 19:32

    1 Timothy 5:17

    1 Timothy 6:15b-16

    1 Peter 2:13-17

    b. What are some specific ways you can show respect and honor to these people in your life?

12. How is it possible to show honor and respect to someone whose decisions and character differ from yours?

13. How might your attitudes and actions set a God-honoring example as you respond to governing authorities?

Sixth Day: Review Romans 13:1-7.

God sovereignly places people in positions of authority.

14. How did this week's lesson challenge how you have viewed submission to authority? What will you do in response, and why?

Homiletics for Group and Administrative Leaders: Romans 13:1-7

Next step: Continue this lesson with group discussion, lecture, and notes.

Lecture Notes

Lesson 23 Notes

Romans 13:1-7

Focus Verse

"Let everyone be subject to the governing authorities, for there is no authority except that which God has established. The authorities that exist have been established by God." (Romans 13:1)

Outline

- God Establishes Governance – Romans 13:1-4
- God Establishes Honor – Romans 13:5-7

Engage

How do you respond when you hear the word "submit"? This term often evokes strong and varied reactions. When the words "be subject to the governing authorities" appear, challenging questions arise. What if the person to whom we are supposed to submit is disrespectful, rude, overdemanding, or downright oppressive? Does God really mean for everyone to be subject to governing authorities? Paul wrote his letter to Roman believers during the reign of the evil emperor Nero, who was known for his immoral and tyrannical behavior. **Yet, Paul's proclamation remains: Every person is responsible to submit to those in authority, without exception.** Even to leaders like Nero. How could Paul expect this, and why would God command it?

Chapter 13 continues right where Paul left off in chapter 12, taking even deeper his call to transformed living. People with renewed minds and changed hearts live counter to culture. They show mercy, love well, and put feet to their faith as they serve God and others. Transformed living extends to how believers relate to all authority. Paul does not state what he expects but rather what God requires: obedient submission to those in charge. Why? **God sovereignly places people in positions of authority.** Our submission to those authorities honors God. When we do not submit, we rebel, not only against the person over us but against God Himself. God sees and knows all things. We can trust that God is in control of every circumstance as He places people in positions of authority.

God Establishes Governance – Romans 13:1-4

In chapter 12, Paul exhorted believers to live with transformed hearts and minds—quite different from worldly patterns. **God's admonition to love well carries through to all aspects of life, including submission to authority.** God's sovereignty over all things includes those in authority within our families, workplaces, and governments.

Authority From God – 13:1

Throughout history, God has established governments. He positions officials for His ultimate glory and for our good. When godly leaders govern well, we easily praise God for His control over the nations. However, when rulers or leaders disappoint us, we can easily doubt God and His sovereign choice. Paul penned Romans and several other New Testament letters while under the evil rule of Nero. Jewish believers had endured mistreatment under the Roman Empire, including the recent expulsion from Rome by Emperor Claudius in AD 49. Though they were later permitted to return, Jewish Christians would have wrestled with viewing their leaders as worthy of submission. Their reintegration into the Roman church likely raised questions about how a minority group should live under Roman rule. Only a few years after Paul penned his letter, Nero would launch a brutal wave of persecution against Christians. Meanwhile, taxes were also a contentious topic in Rome, prompting debate about appropriate loyalty and obedience.

Many ruthless rulers have left grievous scars on nations in the centuries that followed Nero, and tyrants will continue to rise. Are we subject even to these rulers? Even democratically elected officials regularly disappoint us. What are we to do? **Because God has established these authorities, we have the responsibility to submit to them.** However, their authority has limits set by God.

Human powers may be lawful or unlawful. Christians are under no obligation to obey unlawful powers or immoral laws. For example, the power of a robber with a gun is both an unlawful and immoral power. Following the prophets' example, God's people are also free to speak out against governmental injustices. Good citizens can be faithful in keeping laws and also in critiquing government where appropriate, regardless of who is in power.[1] In just societies, lawful powers intervene to protect citizens from the unlawful. Jesus justly exerts His power to intervene on behalf of Christians when Satan uses his power to bring them harm. The power of death reigns on earth, but Jesus's power reigns supreme and for eternity. **One future day, Jesus, our rightful ruler, will return and reign without rival forever.[2]**

Every earthly nation's power originates with God, whether that nation acknowledges God or not. Paul repeatedly used the word "authority" (*exousia* in Greek), meaning power that is delegated, not inherent. Delegated power implies accountability and limits. To understand these limits, we need to recognize the nature of the authority God grants to human governments.

Government's Responsibility – 13:2-4

Knowing that God gives rulers their authority compels Christians to honor God by obeying the law. To disobey human rulers expresses rebellion against God and what He has instituted. Paul further challenged his readers with the truth that rebellion brings judgment. Those who do right by their government have no need to fear but will be commended. Those who do wrong, however, should fear the consequences their government will bring.[3] Does this mean Christians must obey human government in every situation? If not, when may we rightly refuse the government's demands?

1. **Speaking out against injustice:** Exodus 5:1-2; 2 Samuel 12:7-9; 1 Kings 18:18; 21:20-21; Isaiah 1:23; 10:1-2; Jeremiah 22:13; Ezekiel 22:27-29; Daniel 5:22-23; Micah 3:1-3, 9-11
2. **Power of death:** John 10:10; Hebrews 2:14-15
3. **Accountability for wrongdoing:** Acts 25:11

God's Sovereignty over Wicked Rulers

God is sovereign over all things; His power knows no limits. Some human rulers choose to follow Him while others defy Him. **God holds all history in His strong grip.** Even wicked rulers are subject to God and His sovereignty. We will consider this truth by examining three biblical examples.

Pharaoh – The pharaoh in Exodus brutally enslaved the Israelites. He refused God's demand through Moses to let God's people go. Sovereign and powerful God used Pharaoh to accomplish His own purposes—to proclaim His name in all the earth.[1] **God displayed His glory when He protected and provided for His people and unleashed His powerful wrath against Pharaoh.** The proud king suffered the consequences of his rebellion against God.

***Nebuchadnezzar* – Babylon's King Nebuchadnezzar learned painfully that God controls all things.** The Babylonian army had conquered Jerusalem. They had looted, defiled, and destroyed God's temple.[2] Nebuchadnezzar imagined himself to be superior to Israel's God. Such pride equates with insanity. Nebuchadnezzar lost his mind and lived like an animal until he repented. He then confessed that God's "dominion is an eternal dominion. ... He does as he pleases with the powers of heaven and the peoples of the earth."[3]

Pontius Pilate – Pilate, the Roman governor who presided over Jesus's trial before His crucifixion, quickly discovered that Jesus and His kingdom posed no imminent threat to Rome.[4] However, fearing the Jewish leaders who plotted Jesus's arrest, Pilate attempted to help Jesus without risking his position. He asked Jesus, "Don't you realize I have power either to free you or to crucify you?"[5] Jesus's reply perfectly expressed the relationship between God's sovereignty and the authority of civil government. Jesus said, "You would have no power over me if it were not given to you from above."[6] The word Pilate and Jesus used for power is the exact same Greek word translated in Romans 13 as "authority." As governor, Pilate was given by God the right to judge. Yet, God held Pilate accountable for his actions and the authority delegated to him. Peter later explained that wicked men put Jesus to death, but God had full knowledge and control of the situation.[7] **God held Pilate and the Jewish leaders responsible for Jesus's death even while their chosen evil actions fulfilled God's deliberate plan.**

1. **God's sovereignty and Pharaoh:** Exodus 1–14; Romans 9:16-18
2. **Temple destroyed:** 2 Kings 25:8-9; Daniel 1:2
3. **Eternal dominion:** Daniel 4:34-35
4. **Pilate's discovery:** John 18:36-37
5. **Pilate's power:** John 19:10
6. **God's power:** John 19:11
7. **God's plan:** Acts 2:23

Government's Extent and Limits – God institutes government. So how far does its power extend? Jesus answered this question when the Pharisees tried to entrap Him by asking if it was right to pay taxes to Caesar. They posed the question so that either way Jesus answered, He would offend someone. If He said yes, He would be accused of favoring Rome. Had Jesus answered no, the Roman authorities would have arrested Him. But Jesus did neither. He took a coin used for paying taxes and asked, "Whose image is this? And whose inscription?" The Pharisees responded, "Caesar's." Jesus replied, "So give back to Caesar what is Caesar's, and to God what

is God's."[4] Jesus both honored Caesar's authority and established limits on him. **Though every government—whether God-fearing, tyrannical, or oppressive—has legitimate authority, God's authority is greater.** Therefore, we are responsible to obey God even if doing so means facing the consequences of disobeying "Caesar."

When should Christians disobey their governments? In what situations does responsibility to God matter more than human laws? To answer these questions, consider three areas of importance: evangelism, morality, and the nature of government.

- **Evangelism—If governing authorities outlaw spreading the gospel or talking about Jesus, believers must faithfully depend on God's sovereign power.** When Jewish leaders jailed Peter and John for proclaiming Jesus's resurrection, the apostles asked, "Which is right in God's eyes: to listen to you, or to him? ... As for us, we cannot help speaking about what we have seen and heard."[5] Again arrested and commanded to keep silent, the apostles refused and persisted, saying, "We must obey God rather than human beings!"[6] Throughout the centuries, Christians have been threatened, beaten, imprisoned, persecuted, and killed. Believers in the early Church rejoiced that they were counted worthy to suffer for Christ and boldly shared the gospel.[7]
- **Morality—No government has the right to command people to sin, which includes not only doing wrong but also failing to do what is right.** When God's people obey Him rather than sinful laws, they follow in the footsteps of believers such as the Hebrew midwives who defied Pharaoh to save the lives of baby boys.[8] Esther risked her royal position and even her life to plead for her people.[9] Daniel and his friends followed Jeremiah's advice and worked for peace and prosperity in Babylon.[10] They also chose to face death rather than obey Babylonian commands to disregard God and stop worshipping Him.[11] Many in the early Church faithfully refused Rome's demand and stood for God, choosing to die rather than proclaim Caesar as Lord. These and countless others join the great cloud of witnesses whose costly obedience encourages all believers to follow Jesus at any cost.[12] At times, governments not only pressure people to act immorally but also participate in immoral activity. When leaders or rulers consistently ignore righteous actions or act unjustly, believers may need to do more than speak out. Corrie ten Boom and her family acted against their government on behalf of Jews in the Netherlands during World War II. In the 1950s and 1960s, Martin Luther King Jr. led the civil rights movement in the United States. God led these believers to pursue righteousness and justice in their countries.
- **Nature of Government—God grants governments the right and the power to enforce their laws and decrees.** Paul stated, "If you do wrong, be afraid, for rulers do not bear the sword for no reason." The sword, in this case, means force. Governments worldwide exercise their God-given authority using force. Whether through democracy or dictatorship, military might or pacifism, all human governments exert force of some kind. Even so, these verses do not say that any government holds the right to misuse power—to starve or oppress people, forbid worship, or promote evil.

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4. **Caesar and God:** Matthew 22:15-22
5. **Seen and heard:** Acts 4:1-20
6. **Obey God:** Acts 5:17-29
7. **Early Church and the gospel:** Acts 5:41; 1 Peter 4:12-14
8. **Hebrew midwives:** Exodus 1:15-21
9. **Esther:** Esther 4
10. **Peace and prosperity:** Jeremiah 29:4-9; Daniel 1
11. **Babylonian commands:** Daniel 3; 6
12. **Cloud of witnesses:** Hebrews 12:1

Governments rely on "the sword" for external and internal defense. **Externally, governments use their power to defend their people from other nations.** Nations hold the power to wage war and exert power in warfare. They may use their God-given authority to compel people into military service or to pay taxes to support war efforts. They may redirect the nation's economy for wartime. Only a need for common defense justifies these legitimate powers. Any action that goes beyond defending those entrusted to their care misuses the authority God grants those leaders.

In anarchy, no one is safe. **Therefore, internally, the state has power to protect people from wrongdoing.** God has given governments the power and responsibility to establish, exercise, and maintain justice and social order to safeguard citizens. Without government, evil freely damages and destroys everything in its path.

> *God has given governments the power and responsibility to establish, exercise, and maintain justice and social order to safeguard citizens.*

Both Peter and Paul wrote letters during a time when Christians were increasingly seen as internal enemies by Roman authorities. The apostles repeated God's wisdom that Christians are not to act subversively in their communities but transform society through the gospel's message of peace. **Speaking to believers in Rome, Paul wrote, "For the one in authority is God's servant for your good."** He continued by explaining that rulers bear the sword as God's servants, entrusted to bring punishment upon wrongdoers. Peter similarly exhorted God's people to submit to every human authority for the Lord's sake and that God desires believers to silence the talk of foolish people by doing good. Peter called God's people to show respect to all people, love fellow believers, fear God, and honor the emperor.[13] When God's people behave this way, God is honored and glorified.

God Establishes Honor – Romans 13:5-7

Paul offered reasons for Christian submission to lawful authority. **God establishes human governments.** Both God and governing authorities will enact judgment on disobedience. Even so, laws cannot make people good or morally right. While laws may exist that enforce morality, no governmental power or effort can truly transform a wrongdoer without God's intervention and the Holy Spirit's work.

Conscience and Taxes – 13:5-6

Paul continued with a clarifying addition: "Submit to the authorities, not only because of possible punishment but also because of conscience." Conscience involves our internal sense of right and wrong and personal awareness that we should do what is right. In other words, conscience leads us to obey because obedience is right. Because human conscience is fallible, God guides believers through the Holy Spirit, our divine helper who supplies the desire to please God and the power to obey Him. Walking with God in the power of His Spirit creates fresh renewal in the hearts of believers every day.

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13. Do good: Titus 3:1; 1 Peter 2:13-17

God's Sovereign Power

The Doctrine of the Sovereignty of God

Paul called believers to trust God's firm control over all human leaders and governments. He also made it clear that anyone who rebels against human leaders actually rebels against God and will face judgment. Governing authorities are God's servants. We live in a world where mighty people seem almost invincible. We can easily forget that God rises above as the ruler of all rulers—the King of all kings. No human ruler has power that God has not allowed.[1] Every leader throughout time is established and used by God to accomplish His purposes and advance His plan. We can trust God's sovereignty over all governing authorities.

God is sovereign; He has absolute authority and rule over His creation.[2] By His wise purpose, God determines the outcome of all things. Because God knows all things, nothing surprises Him. God knows every thought that motivates each person who holds a position of authority. God does not adjust His plans in response to historical events nor does He wait to see what people will do before He acts. God's sovereign decrees govern history.[3]

Failure to believe in God's sovereignty undermines trust in God. We tend to depend on our own knowledge or opinions or those of others, which lack God's wisdom. We often see injustice and feel helpless. Without trusting God and His sovereign rule, we resist His command to submit to authority. This can create strife in our family relationships, workplaces, and even within ourselves. Ultimately, those in authority over us receive their authority from God. Tragically, our failure to submit to authority brings God's judgment upon us.

Trusting God's sovereign nature brings peace to a believer's heart. Firm belief in God's wisdom and knowledge allows us to submit to those in authority. Certainly, submission to authority brings challenges in this fallen world. Knowing who God is and how He works, we can turn to Him in prayer and trust His sovereign purposes. Though difficulties may persist, the Holy Spirit brings help and comfort in times of trouble and temptation. Above all else, we seek to obey God as we give honor and respect to those in authority over us, even when doing so is difficult. God is on His throne; no human ruler can overrule the King of eternity. God is worthy of our trust.[4]

1. **God's sovereignty over leaders:** Proverbs 21:1-2; Daniel 2:20-23; Romans 13:1b
2. **God's authority over creation:** 1 Chronicles 29:11-12; Psalm 47:7; Ephesians 1:11
3. **God's decrees:** Acts 17:24-27
4. **Security in God:** Romans 8:31-39

Like Jesus, Paul did not leave room for excuses or special circumstances regarding obedience to God, including paying taxes. In Jesus's time, few honest tax collectors existed, and the people were oppressed through taxation.[14] Most people today also do not enjoy paying taxes. But Paul explicitly said in the next verse, "If you owe taxes, pay taxes." Government is expensive, and some governments are corrupt. However, all governments benefit their people in some ways. Taxes often support education, libraries, highways, roads, ports, firefighters, police, and national security. Taxes

14. Tax collectors: Matthew 5:46; 18:17; Luke 3:12-13; 19:1-10

may also fund garbage collection, food inspectors, and public health programs. Regardless of how much or little the government provides, Jesus's followers are called to thank God for these services and pay taxes.

Respect and Honor – 13:7

Christian responsibility to governing authorities extends to offering honor and respect to all those in authority over us. This applies to not just our national government but also local governments, families, workplaces, and churches. The Bible tells us to honor kings,[15] church officers,[16] parents,[17] and older people.[18] **God sovereignly places people in positions of authority.** When we submit to God, we will seek His help to honor and respect even flawed leaders. Therefore, "If you owe taxes, pay taxes; if revenue, then revenue; if respect, then respect; if honor, then honor." Ultimately, we honor our God, who deserves our allegiance above all else.[19]

Take to Heart

Hold Fast

In Romans 13, Paul continued his explanation of Christian service and love that he began in chapter 12. **Paul left no stone unturned as he presented the challenge of submitting to human authority.** Our inborn desire for autonomy and control makes submitting to other people difficult. However, God's sovereignty over all in authority grounds a believer's response to human leaders in all realms, whether just or unjust. Because God rules every believer's heart and establishes every ruler, those in authority have some rightful claim on our submission. However, our obedience and allegiance to God set boundaries for our obedience to human leaders. When human laws, policies, or leaders conflict with God's commands, God calls us to obey Him.

Believers honor God when they extend respect and honor to those in authority over them. God calls His people to live rightly by paying taxes and living conscientiously with the Holy Spirit's help. Submission to authority can deepen our trust in God, whom we can trust in all things. God wants His children to be good citizens. Trusting God and His sovereignty places our eyes and hearts on Him in life's challenges—even when submitting to those in authority proves difficult. God alone can enable us to give honor to those who deserve honor and respect to those who deserve respect. Through His power, God can make this a reality in the hearts and lives of every believer.

Apply It

Paul did not provide a list of exceptions when discussing submission to governing authorities. Everyone must submit. Even tyrannical, oppressive leaders receive their authority from God. However, God sets boundaries for their delegated power. We struggle living in world systems that often defy God's commands and our convictions. How do we know when we should risk refusing to submit to human leaders? **In a sinful world, believers honor their leaders and obey human laws when doing so does not violate the standards God reveals in His Word.** The Bible provides

15. **Kings:** 1 Peter 2:13-17
16. **Church elders:** 1 Timothy 5:17
17. **Parents:** Exodus 20:12
18. **Older people:** Leviticus 19:32
19. **Honoring God:** 1 Timothy 6:15-16

examples, such as Daniel and his friends, of people who willingly chose to defy human rulers and face death rather than dishonor God. Obeying God may cost us a job, a promotion, or a position of leadership. We may face arrest or even death for speaking out or standing against injustice. But God alone is worthy of our devotion, worship, and praise. His Word acts as our supreme guide. What troubling situation is leading you to seek God's wisdom and trust His sovereignty?

What does submission to governing authorities look like? Simply avoiding controversy or punishment does not constitute submission to authority. What we think and do matters. We are responsible to God for how we respond to those He has placed in authority over us. He cares about our motives and attitudes, not just our actions. With renewed minds that love God and others more than ourselves, we are led by God to reflect Him as we live in this world. What do your attitudes and actions reflect to others? **Faithfully submitting to God's sovereign authority by submitting to those in authority over us expresses our love and honor to Him.** We can trust that God knows what is best and has all power and authority to perfectly carry out His will. God desires not just external conformity but complete renewal of our minds and hearts.

Paul exhorted believers to pay their taxes and offer honor and respect where they are due. What workplace policies, city regulations, or national laws do you ignore or resist? What fuels your resistance—obedience to God or a desire for your own way? We live in a world that often elevates personal opinions and supposed rights at the expense of others. What fuels your passion—being "right" about your political views or telling others about Jesus? **Believers have the grand opportunity to reveal Jesus's love, power, and purity by respecting and honoring those in authority.** How often do your words to and about your boss, pastor, or political leaders show respect and honor?

God calls His people to see government as ordained by Him to keep peace, protect people, and stop wrongdoers. **We can trust God's sovereignty over all human leaders and governments.** When injustice reigns, how might you choose to trust God to fulfill His purpose and His plan? Our humility, faithfulness, and trust in challenging times may also serve to build the Church and bring God great glory. God is sovereign over all circumstances and all people. Christians are responsible to God for how they respond to those He has placed in authority over them. How will you trust God to use every authority He has placed in your life for His good purposes?

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